

The New **Lingua Franca**

Coffee Badging: Showing up briefly at the office to mark attendance, then leaving to work remotely

Quiet Thriving: Doing meaningful, satisfying work without chasing titles, visibility, or constant promotion

Quiet Quitting: Doing only what the role requires to protect boundaries and work-life balance—without resigning

Office Peacocking: Redesigning office spaces with perks, aesthetics, and experiences to lure employees onsite

Bare-Minimum Mondays: Doing only essential tasks on Mondays to ease into the week and reduce burnout

Career Catfishing: Accepting a job offer but ghosting the employer by not showing up on the first day

Career Cushioning: Quietly building a safety net through upskilling, networking, and

exploring options to prepare for uncertainty

Boomerang Employees: Professionals who leave an organisation and return later, often in better roles

Leapfrogging (Office Frogging): Intentional job-hopping to fast-track skills, compensation, and culture skipping traditional ladders

Conscious Unbossing: Deliberately avoiding middle management to prioritise autonomy, balance, and mental well-being

Skill Stacking: Building multiple complementary skills instead of following a linear career path

Micro-Retirements: Taking short career breaks for rest, learning, or personal goals instead of waiting till retirement

Quiet Hiring: Companies filling skill gaps internally by reshuffling roles instead of external hiring

Randstad's India findings reinforce this shift: 38% plan to stay in their current jobs for less than a year, underscoring mobility levels far higher than previous generations.

"These are not signs that people don't want to work," says Sashi Kumar, MD of Indeed. "They are signals that people want to work differently." Leaders, he argues, must replace judgement with curiosity. "When we ask what's driving this behaviour, we unlock better conversations—and healthier cultures."

Kumar says careers no longer follow a linear script of study, work, and retirement. Younger workers are questioning whether postponing growth, rest, or exploration until their 60s still makes sense. "Yes, some behaviours stem from burnout," he says. "But there's also a genuine redefinition of ambition. Work still matters, often just after family, but proving commitment by staying late every day feels outdated."

DIFFERENT NOT DISLOYAL

For employers quick to equate mobility with disloyalty, Kumar urges caution. Data from Indeed shows that many employees exhibiting these so-called "disengaged" behaviours are actively upskilling, adopting AI tools, and pursuing multiple learning pathways to stay relevant in a rapidly evolving job market.

This aligns closely with Randstad's finding that 94% of Zoomers in India consider long-term goals when evaluating job opportunities. In this context, loyalty is increasingly defined by contribution. Employees may stay for shorter stints, but they expect those periods to be intense, developmental, and mutually beneficial.

Organisations that recognise this are better positioned to extract value even within shorter tenure cycles. Kumar notes that companies responding with curiosity rather than judgement are far more

